

The Civic Digest

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FRONT PAGE

Here We Go Again

Penny Arcade

Ronia is, in fact, on stage jumping around going fucking crazy in Mamma Mia, which is essentially like a jazzercise class with a lyric book. Like, on some Tae Bo shit. I would last part of one song before my lungs tried to crawl out of my mouth. Gabriel was under some misconceptions regarding the production that I was happy to correct by striking him repeatedly with one of those little ice fishing bats. Did you know that those little clubs are called “priests”? Gabriel didn’t know either. I made sure he understood as it was coming down .

FEATURES

Bowflex SelectTech Adjustable Dumbbells Are Over 50% Off in the Amazon Spring Sale

Eric Song · IGN

Why pay \$479 for a brand new pair of Bowflex adjustable dumbbells? As part of Amazon's Mega Spring Sale, Amazon Resale is offering a pair of used "like new" Bowflex Results Series SelectTech 552 Adjustable Dumbbells for just \$227.99 with free shipping after an extra 40% off discount is applied during checkout. I haven't seen Bowflex dumbbells sell for this low of a price for at least a few years. You better hurry because Amazon Resale inventory is usually limited.

Amazon Resale (formerly Amazon Warehouse) is Amazon's official account for used goods. The products are sorted by condition, with "Like New" being the best. There's a good chance these items haven't been used at all and were returns from customers who have changed their minds, or simply products with blemished packaging. All Amazon Resale items also get the same 30-day return policy as any other Amazon purchase.

Get Bowflex SelectTech Adjustable Dumbbells (Pair) for \$228

Used "Like New" Condition

Update: If the link lands on a "Very Good" condition item, click on the "Other sellers on Amazon" link to see more buying options, including the "Like New" condition item.

Each Bowflex dumbbell is adjustable from 5 pounds all the way up to 52.5 pounds with 15 total increments, so it's essentially like 15 total weights in one package. The SelectTech dumbbells have been around for a long time. Many people, including myself, have used them for well over a decade with no problems. The structural components and moving parts are made of metal wrapped in plastic and rubber to protect against dings, deaden vibrations, and provide better grip. The "Results Series" is just an aesthetic redesign of the original Bowflex SelectTech 552 dumbbells that happened after Johnson Health Tech took over all of Bowflex's assets.

Free weights are a great choice for anyone who wants to work out at home but is limited on space. A pair of dumbbells is all the equipment you need to get access to a wide range of exercises that can target just about every muscle in your upper and lower body. Supplement your free weight exercises with cardio and other workouts that use your own body weight as resistance (like pushups, burpees, or squats) and you may never need to purchase more equipment.

If these are still out of your budget, there are some other options and more fitness deals to check out this week.

Shop More Fitness Deals from Amazon's Spring Sale

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Eric Song is the IGN commerce manager in charge of finding the best gaming and tech deals every day. When Eric isn't hunting for deals for other people at work, he's hunting for deals for himself during his free time.

The SelectTech dumbbells have been around for a long time.

Eric Song

Crimson Desert fans praise the devs for quickly and directly addressing player complaints and requests: ‘This is what game studios should aspire to be’

Andrej Barovic · Destructoid

As Crimson Desert continues to see a ton of success 10 days after launch, players are now praising developer Pearl Abyss for how quickly it's been addressing issues since the moment the game released. With this latest patch, a lot of concerns were directly resolved, improved, or patched out, while some quirks were even embraced as official mechanics.

Soaring through the Steam charts and peaking at over 270,000 players, Crimson Desert is definitely faring a lot better than it did on launch day. It even managed to rebound its Steam reviews, now being labeled as “very positive”—a significant upgrade over its initial “mixed” reception. And all of this has to do with Pearl Abyss' patches, which have improved the game to such a degree that I find myself feeling as if I'm playing a different game, especially coming off the review build.

This latest patch added five entirely new mounts to the game, made sprinting a lot less of a hassle by reducing how much button mashing you need to do (a major complaint since release), made cooking more intuitive, made fast travel much faster, and even added certain currencies that make the upgrade process a lot cheaper and easier early on. This is just scratching the surface, though, and fans have been reacting more than positively since it came out.

Visual representation of players hugging the dev team.
Image via Pearl Abyss

In one thread, a player said that “This is what game studios should aspire to be,” praising Pearl Abyss for addressing the sprinting mechanic mentioned above. “Shout out to the devs for listening to people,” said another.

Some showed that you can never please everyone despite your best efforts, as those replying to the thread said, in no small number, that they preferred how things were before the patch. I'm certain this will eventually lead to Pearl Abyss adding in optional control schemes once everything is fleshed out, allowing everyone to tailor their own fun to themselves, much as the game lets you do things at your own pace and leisure.

In another thread, a player said about Pearl Abyss that “they listen, and they deliver,” as well as that it's the “best dev team ever.”

“They really do. Love the changes,” said another.

It's certainly amazing to see a developer team actually invest the time and effort necessary to make its game as good as it can possibly be. It's gotten to the point where so many player complaints have been fixed or just made better that the game now has an 80 percent positive rating on Steam

and is slowly but surely climbing in player numbers despite being a singleplayer game that came out 10 days ago.

I love to see it, even if I myself don't agree with all the changes that have been made. Other developers need to take note.

The post Crimson Desert fans praise the devs for quickly and directly addressing player complaints and requests: ‘This is what game studios should aspire to be’ appeared first on Destructoid .

Unknown · TechCrunch

1. Yoast SEO

Samsung's Premium 65" S90 4K OLED Smart TV Drops to Just \$1,099 for the Amazon Spring Sale

Eric Song · IGN

As part of its mega Spring Sale , Amazon recently dropped the price on one of Samsung's best OLED TVs. The highly rated 65" Samsung S90D 4K OLED Smart TV has just dropped in price to \$1,099 with free delivery. This is a new TV with a 1 year Samsung warranty. We recently named the Samsung S90 TV as our top pick for best gaming TV . The Amazon marketplace seller "Walt's TV" is an authorized Samsung reseller.

65" Samsung S90D 4K OLED TV for \$1,099

The Samsung S90D is the prior generation 2024 model. A new "S90F" model is available for about \$250 more, but the differences are minor. The S90D is equipped with Samsung's proprietary quantum dot (QD) OLED panel. QD OLED panels are brighter than traditional OLED panels without losing the color accuracy, range, and wide-viewing angles that OLEDs are known for. Compared to a traditional LED LCD TV, an OLED TV offers superior image quality, near-infinite blacks, near-infinite contrast ratio, and near-instantaneous response times.

OLED technology aside, the Samsung S90D also has all the features you'd want in a gaming TV . It has a native 120Hz panel that can be pushed to as high as 144Hz as well as four total HDMI 2.1 ports for running 4K at 120Hz on a PS5 or Xbox Series X gaming console. The S90D also supports variable refresh rate and auto low latency mode. This is an es-

pecially good complement to the recently released Playstation 5 Pro console since it can drive more games in quality mode (native 4K @ 120fps) than the standard PS5, which often needs to be set to performance mode (upscaled 4K).

Is this a good TV for the Nintendo Switch 2?

Despite being a current generation console, the Nintendo Switch 2 has lax TV requirements compared to the PS5 or Xbox Series X. When the Switch is connected to its dock and a television, it is only capable of outputting a 4K resolution signal at up to 60 frames per second. It can go up to 120fps if the resolution drops to 1080p, but the data rate required for both these options is pretty much the same. Oddly, it doesn't even get VRR when docked - that's reserved for handheld mode only. The Switch 2 console, however, will still benefit greatly from the Samsung's gorgeous OLED panel.

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Weekly Update 483

Troy Hunt

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Building out an IoT environment is a little like the old Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs. All the stuff on the top is only any good if all the stuff on the bottom is good, starting with power. This week, I couldn't even get that right, but thankfully, sparky to rescue and ensuite underfloor heating disconnected, and we now have reliable power again. On top of that is the layer that has increasingly been my nemesis - the network. Two days after recording, I've just spent the better part of the entire day making a much more concerted effort to adjust channel and power settings on APs, lock clients that don't move to the APs that make the most sense, and generally just screw around with it until stuff worked. And then I turned off a circuit, turned it back on again, and all hell broke loose 🤖

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Fire In The Hole

Penny Arcade

I've been trying to have a beer with Kim Swift for about five years now, and it finally happened. She suggested The Bine up in Bothell, and you should draft on that suggestion. I'm afraid I made a pun there without meaning to. But it's also real close to Zulu's , a place you might want to be anyway. Anywhoozle, the last half of the meetup was just her breaking down how Pokopia is a masterclass of game design. A little while later, a sheepish server came over and said, "I don't want to interrupt... but were you talking about Pokopia?"

She was.

ANALYSIS

Remaking the app store

Benedict Evans

There's very little we can say about Apple's App Store policies that we didn't say when it launched in 2008, in 2011 when it first tightened the rules, or in 2020, when Epic tried to stunt its way out of them. Meanwhile, the world has moved on: generative AI is the centre of tech innovation, excitement and company creation now, not smartphone apps. The Vision Pro might swing the pendulum back to AR/VR and Apple, but not for years. Seen from Silicon Valley, this is an argument from a decade ago.

That time-lag itself is a broader structural problem: the decision-cycle of regulation and due process tends to be longer than the life-cycle of technology platform. Everyone in the regulation industry is very conscious of that, but the alternative is to speculate about the future development of markets that don't exist yet, and that has its own problems, as the FTC found when it tried to stop Meta from buying Within. Pick your trade-off.

And yet, this platform is the primary computing device for over a billion people, and with the DMA we have a big new law from the EU that tells Apple it has to change things. There's also a court ruling in the USA (rather narrower and focused on Apple's anti-steering rule), and perhaps more coming from a rumoured DoJ/FTC lawsuit. Apple has responded with a very broad set of proposals and changes to how things work, or might work. These are not at all what people who wanted change hoped to see. However it's much less clear whether they are what the EU wanted, or indeed whether it's actually possible to build what the EU wanted... presuming that anyone involved in the DMA actually knows what that is.

The challenge for the EU is that the iPhone proposed a new kind of tradeoff for the software industry. IBM's mainframes gave giant companies a computer and software as one sealed system that IBM controlled. In contrast, the PC was an open system that no-one really controlled (not even Microsoft), where anyone could do anything with their computer, and so could any developer. This was freedom, but it also meant that it was easy for you to break your computer and easy for a developer to break it (accidentally or on purpose), and easy for them to steal your data. When there were millions of PCs, mostly owned by pretty technical people, and they were not connected to an open global network, that was one thing, but once billions of people connected to the internet, that was a big problem.

Hence, the iPhone software model proposed a new level of abstraction and a new trade-off. Random third-party developers cannot do whatever they want with your data or break your computer, and indeed you cannot break your computer. The iPhone puts security, privacy and reliability over the freedom to change anything and do anything. This has been a huge success: iOS has the largest mobile app ecosystem, and indeed the largest software ecosystem there

has ever been, with millions of apps and billions of downloads, which makes it rather incomplete to call it 'closed'.

This is the right trade-off for almost everyone. A small number of highly-technical people would like to be able to change anything on their computer even at the cost of opening security holes everywhere: they are free to buy a different device.

However, Apple uses the control inherent in this model in ways that are sometimes mostly or entirely about Apple, and not about that security, privacy and reliability at all.

Generally, this is a spectrum. Some restrictions are entirely about privacy, security and performance (no, you can't have root access to the file system), but others are also about making life harder for competitors, or extracting rent, or both. Why can't WhatsApp be your default SMS client, say, and why can't Square make a wallet app that uses NFC? There are serious security and ease-of-use answers to this, but also, serious business answers. Banning streaming games services has no security reasoning: it's purely a desire to protect Apple's own ecosystem.

The payment rules are a subset of this, and they have some of the clearest examples. Apple believes that developers should pay it for using the platform (a well-established model on games consoles, but not on PCs or Macs), and it chose to charge them by letting most developers use it for free (Uber and TikTok don't pay anything) but charging a 30% commission for digital content bought inside apps. That sounded simple in 2008, but quickly led to an inverted pyramid of increasingly complex problems, exemptions, carve-outs and edge-cases.

But while you can at least argue whether newspapers should be paying that 30%, Apple again uses this to hurt or block competitors in ways that have no user benefit. The obvious problem right from the beginning was music and ebooks. Neither of these have the gross margin available to pay Apple a 30% commission (meanwhile, Apple's store model has a cap of 10,000 products per app, so you couldn't use it for an ebook store even if you were willing to pay), so they have to use their own subscription, but Apple banned them from telling the user how to do that.

In case there was any doubt, Steve Jobs was very clear about this internally in 2011, in the email below: the new rules introduced in 2011 would preclude some competitors. These rules would be good for users in some ways (see Eddy Cue's comment further down about the app experience) but bad in others.

All of this is to say that you can believe two things.

On one hand, the principle of Apple's sandboxed, managed, curated system (across both the OS sandbox and the store) is great for almost all developers, and users, and Apple. (Apple may or may not see things in that order.) Something over a billion people have an iPhone, and though we sometimes call it 'closed', it has millions of apps and billions of

Folk Etymologies

Penny Arcade

As something of a connected phenomenon - my instinct is to say “corollary,” but I think that’s not correct - as Penny Arcade was unearthed by the wily Zillennial, the many fruits of our enterprise became known. The true facts of the name PAX, for example - a name I came up with in five seconds at Costco because we got a call saying the show thing we were trying to do needed a name. I’m always delighted when someone finds the information I tucked in there. Never you mind that the next question is usually “what’s a Penny Arcade” because that’s not what this story is about!!!

All gods and bonuses in Nova Roma

Arka Sarkar · Destructoid

Religion plays a key role in Nova Roma in deciding if your civilization flies to a new high or meets doom. Dedicating temples to the heavenly powers will help your civilization to grow. Failure to do so can result in its perishing.

Let’s find out all the gods that are present in Nova Roma and the boons each of them offers.

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All god boons in Nova Roma

How to gain Favor from the gods in Nova Roma

All god boons in Nova Roma

The table below has a list of all the gods and the boons they offer.

God Boons Jupiter +3 happiness in a 5 tile radius. Ceres +1 output to the nearest three farms, vineyards, and orchards in its radius. Neptune +1 fish yields to the nearest five fishing buildings in its radius. Vulcan +1 output to the nearest five fire-based industry Ares +25% damage to the nearest three defense towers in its radius.

How to gain Favor from the gods in Nova Roma

Image via Hooded Horse

The first step is to build a temple and then dedicate it to a god of your choice. Your decision will be driven by the potential buffs that you want to apply. Once you dedicate a temple to a god, you’ll need to complete Divine Tasks. Once you complete them, you’ll be rewarded with Favor.

You can then offer Favor to a god in the Small Temple to unlock the benefits (listed above). If you have a Large Temple, you can also throw a festival to gain Favor. Favor is used to unlock new technology spread across several branches. The unlocks will allow you to improve your civilization through time and bring it close to prosperity.

The post All gods and bonuses in Nova Roma appeared first on Destructoid .

Your decision will be driven by the potential buffs that you want to apply.

Arka Sarkar

BRIEFS

IN BRIEF

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Most teams have security tools in place. Alerts are firing, dashboards look clean, threat intel is flowing in. On the surface, everything feels under control. But one question usually stays unanswered: Would your defenses actually stop a real attack? That's where things get shaky. A control exists, so it's assumed to work. A detection rule is active, so it's expected to catch something. But very

Daniel Curtis, InfoQ: Nuxt Test Utils has released version 4.0.0, which primarily integrates Vitest v4. This update changes the test environment setup to beforeAll, resolving issues with module-level mocks. It also improves mockNuxtImport for cleaner partial mocking and enhances state management for registered endpoints. The library remains vital for testing in the Nuxt framework, bridging unit and end-to-end testing.

By Daniel Curtis

Connor Makar, Eurogamer: Bungie has implemented a substantial matchmaking change which will aid those playing from isolated regions - think Australia or South America - find games faster.

Read more

Zack Garvey, PlayStation Blog: PlayStation Store's Spring Sale begins tomorrow, Wednesday, March 25. For a limited time* you can enjoy deep discounts of up to 75% on a vast range of games that include iconic blockbusters, acclaimed classics, and more.

*PlayStation Store Spring Sale promotion runs from Wednesday, March 25 at 00:00 AM PDT/BST/JST and finishes Wednesday April 22 at 11:59 PM PDT/BST/JST**. Each title may have different sale periods. Please refer to the information in the title details page.

**The promotion's start and finish time may differ in certain regions. Game selection may differ by region.

Cerner Engineering, Cerner Engineering: The FHIR standard started as a better way to exchange healthcare data, but it also provides a solid basis for deep analytics and Machine Learning at scale. This post looks at an example from the recent FHIR DevDays conference that does just that. You can also run the interactive FHIR data engineering tutorial used in the conference yourself. Our first step is to bring FHIR data into a data lake – a computational environment where our analysis can easily and efficiently work through petabytes of data.

Victoria Phillips Kennedy, Eurogamer: “I remember being in a really strange time in my life, oddly enough, and a big transition where I felt really uncertain of myself and my place in the world, and this audition came around that was somehow celebrating all the things about myself that I thought were problematic.”

Read more

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Cybersecurity has changed fast. Roles are more specialized, and tooling is more advanced. On paper, this should make organizations more secure. But in practice, many teams struggle with the same basic problems they faced years ago: unclear risk priorities, misaligned tooling decisions, and difficulty explaining security issues in terms the business understands. These challenges do not

Cerner Engineering, Cerner Engineering: At Cerner, we use the latest technologies to transform healthcare. We are the engineers and designers that focus on making you, your family, and friends healthy and happy. We love solving the hard problems that no one else wants to tackle. We embrace polyglot programming, distributed systems, and open source. We also know that it's important to allow engineers to take a step back to learn and try new things. That's why we host periodic hackathons, meetups, tech talks, and an annual internal two-day developers conference.

Bruno Couriol, InfoQ: Max Inden recently explored in a talk at FOSDEM 2026 how the upcoming WebTransport protocol and Web API enhance WebSocket capabilities. WebTransport seeks to provide, among other things, lower latency and transparent network switching for key use cases such as high-frequency financial data streaming, cloud gaming, live streaming, and collaborative editing.

By Bruno Couriol

Robert Purchase, Eurogamer: Hello and welcome back to our regular feature where we write a little about the games we've been playing. This week, Bertie discovers he's not as good at Slay the Spire 2 as he would like to be; Connor continues to fall to the Dark Side and embrace his inner troll; and Marie realises that older games really were more challenging.

Read more

Cerner Engineering, Cerner Engineering: In the dark ages of development, great software meant packing in the functionality. People began doing more and more with their software. Updates meant newer and more exciting functionality. Sounds great, right? Of course it does, but something went horribly wrong. Slowly we became inundated with cluttered screens as software developers struggled to find a place to put their latest innovative functionality. Buttons began adding up and before we knew it, we were inventing user interface controls like ribbons to hold all the buttons.

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Google on Thursday announced a new “advanced flow” for Android sideloading that requires a mandatory 24-hour wait period to install apps from unverified developers in an attempt to balance openness with safety. The new changes come against the backdrop of a developer verification mandate the tech giant announced last year that requires all Android apps to be registered by verified developers to

Victoria Phillips Kennedy, Eurogamer: During last night's Xbox Partner Preview showcase, AdHoc announced that its brilliant superhero workplace comedy Dispatch would be heading over to Microsoft's Series X/S consoles, as well as Xbox on PC and Xbox Cloud.

Read more

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Google on Thursday announced a new “advanced flow” for Android sideloading that requires a mandatory 24-hour wait period to install apps from unverified developers in an attempt to balance openness with safety. The new changes come against the backdrop of a developer verification mandate the tech giant announced last year that requires all Android apps to be registered by verified developers to

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